

House of Commons' Standing Committee on Procedure and House Affairs

Opening Statement by:

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Sean

Thank you, Chair, and members of the committee, for the opportunity to appear today.

My name is Sean Mullin. I'm a Senior Fellow at the Munk School of Global Affairs and Public Policy at the University of Toronto. I'm appearing with my colleague Jaxson Khan, who will introduce himself shortly.

To open this study, we want to make three points.

First, sovereignty and democracy are inextricably linked, particularly when it comes to AI.

Second, AI has the potential to cause serious harm to our democracy and democratic institutions.

Third, Canada needs the state capacity to understand and respond to these threats.

Our starting point is a report we published at the Munk School earlier this year, *Sovereign by Design: Strategic Options for Canadian AI Sovereignty*. It addresses how Canada can benefit from the economic opportunities of AI, while reducing the threats to our sovereignty that this powerful technology could entrench.

The report assesses Canada's AI technology stack across five dimensions of sovereignty. The one most relevant to this committee is what we call **societal sovereignty**: a society's capacity to govern itself without external interference. Can citizens form their views freely? Or are those views increasingly shaped by systems whose rules are set elsewhere?

Put simply, democracy is downstream of sovereignty. Whatever the right protections for our democracy turn out to be, Canada will need the levers to put them in place. That means the ability to test these systems, set rules and require changes. If those levers sit elsewhere, good policy ideas cannot be acted on.

A recent paper from Professor Zhijing Jin's lab at the University of Toronto examines these threats in more detail. The paper, *AI Poses Risks to Democratic and Social Systems*, sets out ways AI can weaken democratic institutions.

First, AI can narrow debate and reinforce existing beliefs. Discourse can narrow as a few similar models mediate what people read. Agreeable, even sycophantic, AI models can validate what people already believe, even when it is wrong.

Second, AI makes it easy to flood public discourse. AI-generated submissions can overwhelm MPs' offices and government consultations, crowding out genuine engagement. Content is now far easier to generate than to verify.

Third, AI can weaken accountability and concentrate power. Automated decisions can become too opaque to audit. Choices about values and norms can shift quietly from elected officials to model designers and external AI companies. And wealth and influence can concentrate in fewer hands.

My colleague Jaxson will speak to what this means for Canada's capacity to respond.

Jaxson

Thank you, Chair. My name is Jaxson Khan, and I'm also a Senior Fellow at the Munk School.

We don't claim to have all the solutions to these risks. But whatever policy choices Parliament makes, one thing is essential: Canada cannot effectively regulate what it cannot understand or evaluate.

That means knowing how these systems behave in Canadian political and legal contexts, and in both official languages.

Today, the bodies best equipped to evaluate frontier models are the leading AI labs, a few independent evaluators, and select national AI safety and security institutes. Little of this capacity sits in Canada, so we rely largely on the judgment of others.

This is where questions on sovereignty and state capacity meet.

The UK's AI Security Institute is an example of what is possible. It has a prominent role within the UK government, attracts top technical talent, and has published evaluations of frontier models such as Mythos.

In our view, the Canadian AI Safety Institute (CAISI) could develop similar capabilities, including by continuously reviewing models for risks to democracy and society. A strong CAISI is an important precondition for effective oversight of AI.

That capacity will also matter if the global technology stability body the Prime Minister has proposed goes ahead. Its model, the Financial Stability Board, works because national entities like central banks and finance departments possess deep technical expertise on financial policy. Strong national AI safety institutes could play a similar role in a global body coordinating safe and responsible AI. If Canada wants its seat at that table to count, CAISI needs that strengthened capacity.

Protecting our democracy will take both technical capacity and political judgment. CAISI can provide the first. Parliament has a central role in the second. Both are part of what sovereignty means for our democracy.

Thank you. We look forward to your questions.